“They are going to keep going. And we are going to try to shoot the rudder off, or the boiler. And we’re going to try to board it. And they’re going to fire a gun, then machine guns. And we’re going to have one hell of a time trying to get aboard that thing and getting control of it, because they’re pretty tough, and I suppose there may be armed soldiers or marines aboard their ships.” “Or they might give orders to blow it up or something,” responded Robert Kennedy, continuing that line of thought. He was no longer insisting on the interception of Soviet ships. Ultimately, he was there to support his brother. In his memoirs he said nothing about his hawkish stand but praised his brother’s prudence and caution.[8]

After 7:00 p.m., when everyone had left, and John and Robert were alone, they reflected on the situation created by Khrushchev’s deception and the declaration of the blockade. “It looks like hell—looks real mean. Doesn’t it?” said the president to his brother. He then added: “But on the other hand, there is no other choice. If they get this mean on this one, it’s just a question of where they go about it next. No choice. I do not think there was a choice.” John Kennedy had Khrushchev’s policies in mind, but Robert was also thinking of the domestic situation. “Well, there isn’t any choice. I mean, you would have been, you would have been impeached.” The president did not disagree. “That’s what I think,” he told Robert. “I would have been impeached.”

Robert Kennedy wondered whether he could do a better job by helping his brother to establish a back channel to the Soviets. John Kennedy was still hurt by what he called Khrushchev’s “horseshit about the election,” delivered by Robert’s main confidential contact, the Soviet intelligence officer Georgii Bolshakov. John Kennedy brought up his name: what did he have to say about the instructions given to the Soviet captains? “He said they are going to go through.” Robert Kennedy no longer sounded like a reckless teenager looking for any opportunity to get into a fight. Instead, he suggested that it might be a good idea to have Soviet ships inspected by boarding parties consisting not only of Americans but also of OAS representatives. Should conflicts arise over the boarding of ships, he preferred that they be international rather than exclusively American. The latter might lead directly to war.[9]